STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE			AU-15300	
	SARPY COUNTY SHERIFF'S OFFICE PAPILLION * NEBRASKA **GREG LONDON** **SHERIFF**	DATE ISSUED **05/22/25**	DATE REVISED	DATE REVIEWED
		APPROVED: *GREG LONDON*		
CHAPTER TITLE AUXILIARY UNITS: SMALL UNMANNED AIRCRAFT SYSTEM (sUAS)		RESOURCES		
SUBJECT sUAS OPERATIONS AND TRAINING		CROSS REFERENCE		

I. Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is it to provide guidance to personnel trained in the responsibilities, deployment, and use of small Unmanned Aircraft Systems (sUAS).

II. Policy:

Rapidly advancing technology in law enforcement has led the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office to employ small, unmanned aircraft systems (sUAS) to assist with law enforcement operations. This policy will outline the procedures to ensure personnel operating a sUAS are following the mandates of the U.S. Constitution, Federal, State, and local laws governing the commercial operation of sUAS.

III. Definitions:

A. **Model Aircraft:** A remote-controlled aircraft used by hobbyists, which is manufactured and operated for sport, recreation, and /or competition.

B. **Unmanned Aircraft (UA):** An aircraft that is intended to navigate in the air without an onboard pilot. These aircraft are also commonly referred to as a Remotely Piloted Aircraft or Drone.

C. **Unmanned Aircraft System (UAS):** A system that includes the necessary equipment, network, and personnel to control an unmanned aircraft.

D. **Small Unmanned Aircraft Systems (sUAS**): A small, unmanned aircraft weighing less than 55 pounds and its associated elements

(including communication links and the components that control the small, unmanned aircraft) that are required for the safe and efficient operation of the small, unmanned aircraft in the national airspace system.

E. **Part 107**: A set of rules in the Code of Federal Regulations (CFR) Title 14 Part 107 for operating sUAS.

F. **Remote Pilot in Command (RPIC**): A person who holds a remote pilot certificate with an sUAS rating and has the final authority and responsibility for the operation and safety of an sUAS operation conducted under FM part 107.

G. **Visual Observer:** A person whose primary duty is to assist the RPIC with scanning the airspace surrounding the sUAS operation to detect and avoid any other aircraft or obstacles in the airspace or on the ground.

H. **Certificates of Waiver or Authorization (COA**): An authorization issued by the FAA to a public operator for specific Unmanned Aircraft (UA) activities.

I. **Special Government Interest (SGI) Certificate of Waiver:** An authorization issued by the FAA to a public operator specific to unmanned Aircraft (UA) activities in support of an emergency response or effort being conducted to address exigent circumstances and that will benefit the public good. Most generally used in zero airspace in relation to Offutt Air Force Base class “C” airspace.

IV. Procedure:

A. sUAS Specifications and Requirements:

1. The aircraft must be produced by a reputable manufacturer with durable industrial-grade materials capable of dependable operation, suited for the rigors and demands of law enforcement use.

a) The use of model aircraft, modified with cameras or other sensors, is prohibited for law enforcement use due to concerns over reliability and safety.

2. The aircraft must have the capability to capture flight time by individual flight and cumulative over a period of time.

3. Any aircraft used by the Sarpy County Sheriff's Office shall not be armed with any type of weapon.

B. sUAS Operation and Use:

1. sUAS will only be operated by personnel who have been trained and certified in the operation of the system.

a) A sUAS Remote Pilot License/Certification shall be obtained by successfully completing the FAA US CFR14 Part 107 exam at any FAA-approved testing facility.

b) No employee will operate a Sarpy County Sheriff's Office sUAS without a current FAA Remote Pilot License.

c) Taking a preparation training class prior to taking the FAA Remote Pilot test is preferred, but not mandatory.

d) An additional FAA Certificate of Authorization (COA) or FAA waiver may be required to operate the sUAS under special circumstances, such as night operations and flying above populated areas and in controlled airspace.

e) Additional familiarization training including sUAS specifications, related policies and procedures review, and training flights will be given to certified pilots before any official air operations are authorized and conducted.

2. All sUAS flights must be approved by a supervisor and must be for a legitimate public safety mission, training, or demonstration purpose.

3. All sUAS flights must be documented through the AirData records platform. Pilots shall log into AirData to record flight time, location, flight control data, weather conditions, and pre-flight inspections. Remote Pilots should also record additional information in the comments section, such as reason for the flight mission, location (address), report number, and any other information they deem relevant.

4. The designated sUAS Supervisor will audit flight documentation forms and flight data information on AirData quarterly. The results of the flight time audits will be properly documented. Unauthorized reset of

flight time counters or any other AirData information is strictly prohibited and will only be performed by the sUAS Supervisor.

5. The Remote Pilot and approving supervisor will be held accountable for any unauthorized use or misuse of the unmanned aircraft.

6. When there are specific and articulable grounds to believe that the sUAS will intrude upon reasonable expectations of privacy, a search warrant will be obtained prior to conducting a flight.

7. Authorized Uses:

a) Searches for suspects.

b) Searches for victims.

c) Searches for critical missing/suicidal persons.

d) Searches for vulnerable adults and children.

e) Crime scene documentation.

f) Serious/Fatality traffic crash scene investigations.

g) Traffic monitoring.

h) Support of tactical operations.

i) Hazardous material and disaster assessments.

j) Water rescue operations.

k) Monitoring and dispersing any large gatherings by using a speaker-mounted system to notify violators.

l) Any other operation approved by a sUAS Pilot or sUAS Supervisor.

8. The RPIC shall know the limitations of the sUAS and is responsible for determining if the sUAS can and should be deployed. The RPIC has the authority to deny any request to deploy the sUAS based on safety factors and limitations of the sUAS or the Remote Pilot.

9. In the event there are no on-duty Remote Pilots available, the on-duty supervisor or commander may call out a Remote Pilot for any emergency requiring the use of a sUAS. The designated sUAS Supervisor shall be notified of any sUAS call outs.

10. Prior to deployment, a RPIC is responsible for pre-flight checks to include any aircraft damage, checking weather reports, battery levels, area hazards, airspace restrictions, required authorizations, Notice to Airmen, and any other safety conditions.

11. When deploying an sUAS, the Remote Pilot in Command or Visual Observer, if one is being used, is responsible for maintaining an unobstructed visual line of sight with the aircraft during all missions. The RPIC and/or VO must be able to see the aircraft throughout the entire flight to know the sUAS 's location, determine attitude, altitude, and direction of flight. They must also monitor air traffic, watch for other hazards or obstructions, and ensure the aircraft does not endanger the life or property of another.

C. Digital Photographs and Video Evidence:

1. All digital photographs and video evidence shall be retained in accordance with SOP A-7100 Evidence and Property.

D. Equipment Responsibilities and Care:

1. sUAS Pilots are responsible for conducting pre-flight inspections of the sUAS prior to deployment.

2. The sUAS shall not be used and shall be removed from service if there is any damage that may affect flight operations. All repairs to the sUAS will be completed before the sUAS is returned to service.

3. All damage shall be reported to the sUAS Supervisor.

4. Any damage in excess of minor damage (propellers, propeller guards) shall be documented in a report and forwarded to the sUAS supervisor prior to the end of shift.

5. Major damage resulting from an sUAS accident shall be reported to the FAA if required by FAA reporting guidelines.

6. Any FAA reportable sUAS accident or sUAS accident resulting in major damage to any sUAS, person, or property shall be investigated by the sUAS supervisor or his designee in accordance with the Complaint Procedure policy.